deft in the laboratory and I felt that sex was a kind of

laboratory exercise that I was equally undeft at. I had no reason to think otherwise till then. This young lady, however, had apparently had a good time and was kind enough to say so.

For the first time I thought, "Hey . . ."

Now you might think that, having learned this, I instantly plunged into a maelstrom of sex.

Not so. I don't say I wouldn't have liked to, but the fact is that I didn't. I still felt guilty, and so I remained much as I had been before. The proof of it is that my writing continued at the same prodigious rate as before. Anyone who considers my output can see that I must spend virtually (and virtuously) all my time at the typewriter.

Nevertheless, not quite entirely. There were times, once in a rare while, when the occasion offered itself, when a woman would make it clear that it was all right with her, and then, if it seemed all right with me, too, I would allow the matter to work itself out to its logical conclusion.

I have no intention of recounting all the cases and times in clinical detail. My autobiography is not a peep show, but I must tell you enough to account for the way I am, it seems to me, and it is important that in the end, I was satisfied that I was good in bed. Independent evidence all seemed to point in the same direction, with no significant word or action to the contrary.

And, as it happens, though sex has nothing to do with writing or lecturing or any other cerebral occupation, so tightly is sexual achievement tied in with self-esteem that once I gathered I was good in bed, I was automatically far more self-assured in every other respect, and I believe this contributed to the mid-1950s as my peak period in science fiction.

3

I finished The Caves of Steel on May 24, 1953, and I was enormously pleased with it. Fred Pohl was pleased with it. Horace Gold was pleased with it. Horace was never so pleased, however, that he didn't want changes, and he called me up collect to tell me so in a seventeen-minute conversation. Nevertheless, he was going to pay me at the rate of $.04 a word, which meant $2,520 after Fred took his percentage.